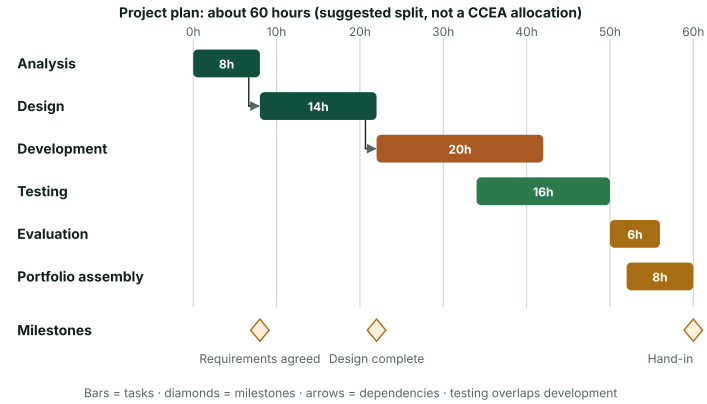
Understanding the task: case study, planning and authentication

AD01 FACT FILE

Specification: students should be able to

- Understand the requirements of the internally assessed A2 2 task: a relational database application produced in response to a CCEA pre-released case study
- Plan and manage a project of about 60 hours using a Gantt chart, milestones and a project log
- Structure the portfolio of evidence so that it follows the stages of the system life cycle
- Understand the rules on academic honesty and authentication of coursework

Key words: case study, client, portfolio, Gantt chart, milestone, dependency, project log, authentication, academic honesty, plagiarism, marking grid, moderation



A Gantt chart for a 60-hour database project showing six tasks, overlapping testing, dependencies and three milestones

The A2 2 task

A2 2 Application Development is the internally assessed unit of the A level, worth 20% of the qualification and taking about 60 hours. Candidates respond to a pre-released CCEA case study by producing a relational database application. Evidence of analysis, design, development, testing and evaluation is presented in a single PDF portfolio. Teachers mark the work against CCEA's marking grid and CCEA moderates a sample. The case study, task instructions and grid should always be checked on the CCEA website for the current year.

Project planning

A Gantt chart lists tasks down the side and time along the top, with a bar for each task's duration. Dependencies link tasks that must happen in sequence, and milestones mark important checkpoints such as agreeing the requirements. The critical path is the longest chain of dependent tasks: any delay on it delays the whole project. A project log records what was actually done, which helps you compare progress with the plan and explain any changes you made to it.

Authentication

Coursework must be the candidate's own work. The candidate and teacher sign declarations, and the teacher must be able to confirm that the work was produced under the required conditions. Sources, tutorials, templates and any permitted AI use must be acknowledged in the portfolio. Copying, collusion or presenting generated content as your own is malpractice and can result in penalties, including disqualification. Keeping dated versions of the database and portfolio shows how the work developed over time.

T Key terms from the mark schemes

Case study
A scenario pre-released by CCEA describing an organisation's problem, which candidates analyse and solve with a database application.

Gantt chart
A planning chart showing each task as a horizontal bar against a timeline, with durations, overlaps and dependencies.

Milestone
A significant checkpoint in a project, such as the completion of a stage, used to monitor progress.

Dependency
A relationship between tasks in which one task cannot start until another has been completed.

Critical path
The longest sequence of dependent tasks in a project; a delay to any task on it delays the whole project.

Authentication
Confirmation by the candidate and teacher that coursework is the candidate's own work, produced under the required conditions.

Exam focus

The moderator only sees your PDF, so evidence must be easy to find and clearly linked. Number your requirements and use those numbers everywhere. Show your process, not just the finished product: a design that changed, with a reason, is stronger evidence than a perfect final screenshot. Avoid unexplained screenshots and generic textbook theory copied into the portfolio; every page should be about your client's system. Read the marking grid headings and make sure each one has clearly labelled evidence.

? Check yourself

1. State what is produced in the A2 2 Application Development task and how the evidence is submitted. [2]
2. Explain why a Gantt chart is useful when planning a 60-hour project. [3]
3. Define the term milestone and give an example from a database project. [2]

Answers: 1. A relational database application that solves the problem in CCEA's pre-released case study (1) / all evidence (analysis, design, development, testing, evaluation) is submitted as a single PDF portfolio (1). 2. A Gantt chart shows each task as a bar against a timeline, so durations and overlaps can be seen (1) / it shows dependencies, i.e. which tasks cannot start until another finishes, e.g. forms need tables first (1) / and milestones, so progress can be checked against the plan and slippage spotted and managed within the 60 hours / hand-in date (1). 3. A milestone is a key point or checkpoint in a project that marks the completion of a significant stage (it has no duration) (1) / example: requirements agreed with the client / design signed off / test plan complete / database tables and relationships built (1).